

Typefounding and the Caslon Family

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Early printing was done by hand. People arranged metal letters into lines using a small tool, then locked them in a frame. They inked the letters and pressed them onto paper.

Type was made by type makers. The most famous were the Caslon family in London. William Caslon the Elder began making clear, easy-to-read type around 1730. His type was used in important documents, including the first printed US Declaration of Independence.

His family continued the work. William Caslon IV later created one of the first sans-serif type styles.

A plaque in Red Lion Court near Fleet Street marks this history.

There is also an illustration showing the fonts and sizes of type available from William Caslon the Elder in 1734.



The picture above shows the sample fonts and sizes of type available from William Caslon the Elder in 1734